Azure Local: Day-2 Readiness Checklist

The line between a deployed cluster and an operable platform. Use this checklist as the acceptance gate before handing the cluster to operations. Each control implements a requirement from the planning phase and reports an evidence state, not just a colour.

Status: prepared 2026-10-06. Results depend on your release and tenant. The matching read-only readiness script in the session repo, `automation/demo/azure-local/scripts/Test-Day2Readiness.ps1`, runs these checks in one pass.

Two gates, not one

Gate	Question	Passed when
Platform validation (end of deployment)	Is the cluster healthy?	Nodes up, witness online, storage healthy, intents successful, Arc Resource Bridge running, custom location present
Operational acceptance (this checklist)	Can operations own it?	Every control below is Verified, or Not applicable with a recorded reason

A cluster can pass the first and fail the second. That is expected, and it is the reason this gate exists.

Evidence states

Every control reports exactly one state:

State	Meaning
Configured	The setting exists; nothing proves it works yet
Pending evidence	Waiting for something that cannot be instant (policy evaluation, first telemetry, a completed backup job)
Verified	The evidence exists and is timestamped
Failed	The control is broken
Not applicable	With the reason written down

The gate never forces a control green. Pending evidence is a legitimate state at handover, with an owner and a date.

Controls

#	Control	Requirement it implements	Evidence that makes it Verified
1	Insights enabled with the cluster data collection rule	Monitoring scope and cost ceiling	Insights shows Configured; the Azure Monitor Agent is on every node; data is flowing (allow up to an hour for first data)
2	Alert rules and action group	Faults are observable	Rules exist for node down, storage health, network intent drift, capacity; a test alert reached the action group
3	VM monitoring data collection rule	Workload visibility	VM Insights data from at least one workload VM

#	Control	Requirement it implements	Evidence that makes it Verified
4	Update management for guests	Maintenance windows	A maintenance configuration exists with a dynamic scope by tag; machines appear in the Update Manager machines view
5	Cluster update readiness	Cluster lifecycle	The update environment reports a healthy state and update history is readable
6	Backup	Recovery within hours	A policy is assigned, a backup job completed, recovery points exist, and a restore was tested
7	Site Recovery	Continuity within minutes (tier 1)	Replication healthy, a test failover completed, a recovery plan exists
8	Privileged access	Eligible, not standing	Roles are assigned as eligible in PIM; an activation produced an audit entry; effective scope checked
9	Defender for Cloud	Security baseline	The plan is enabled on the landing zone; secure score visible
10	Azure Policy baseline	Governance	The initiative is assigned at the landing-zone scope; a compliance scan completed (evaluation is not instant)
11	Node security baseline	Platform security	Security level and drift control as set at deployment; verified by the post-deployment test
12	Workload platform	Targets for VMs and migration	Images are Available; logical networks and IP pools exist; storage paths exist on workload volumes, not on the infrastructure volume
13	Tags and naming	Operability	Required tags present; names follow the standard
14	Documentation	Handover	Runbooks, contact paths and decision log delivered

Acceptance criteria before handover

- [ ] No health faults on the cluster
- [ ] RDMA and data center bridging operational where required
- [ ] Live migration and node failover meet the agreed targets
- [ ] Monitoring, update management, backup, access and governance in place
- [ ] Secure score at the agreed target
- [ ] Backup restore validated
- [ ] DR test failover completed
- [ ] Every Pending evidence item has an owner and a date

Running the checks by hand

```
# Cluster, storage and network health
Get-ClusterNode
Get-StoragePool -IsPrimordial $false | Format-Table FriendlyName, HealthStatus,
OperationalStatus
Get-PhysicalDisk | Where-Object HealthStatus -ne 'Healthy'
Get-StorageJob
```

```
Get-NetIntentStatus | Format-List Host, IntentName, ConfigurationStatus, ProvisioningStatus

# Cluster update environment
Get-SolutionUpdateEnvironment
Get-SolutionUpdate | Format-Table DisplayName, State, Version
```

Reversible by design

Build each control so it can be removed and re-applied from code. That is how a team proves the platform is reproducible, and how a rehearsal restores a known state. Keep backup data, replication, privileged-access eligibility and the workload platform out of any reset, because other work depends on them.